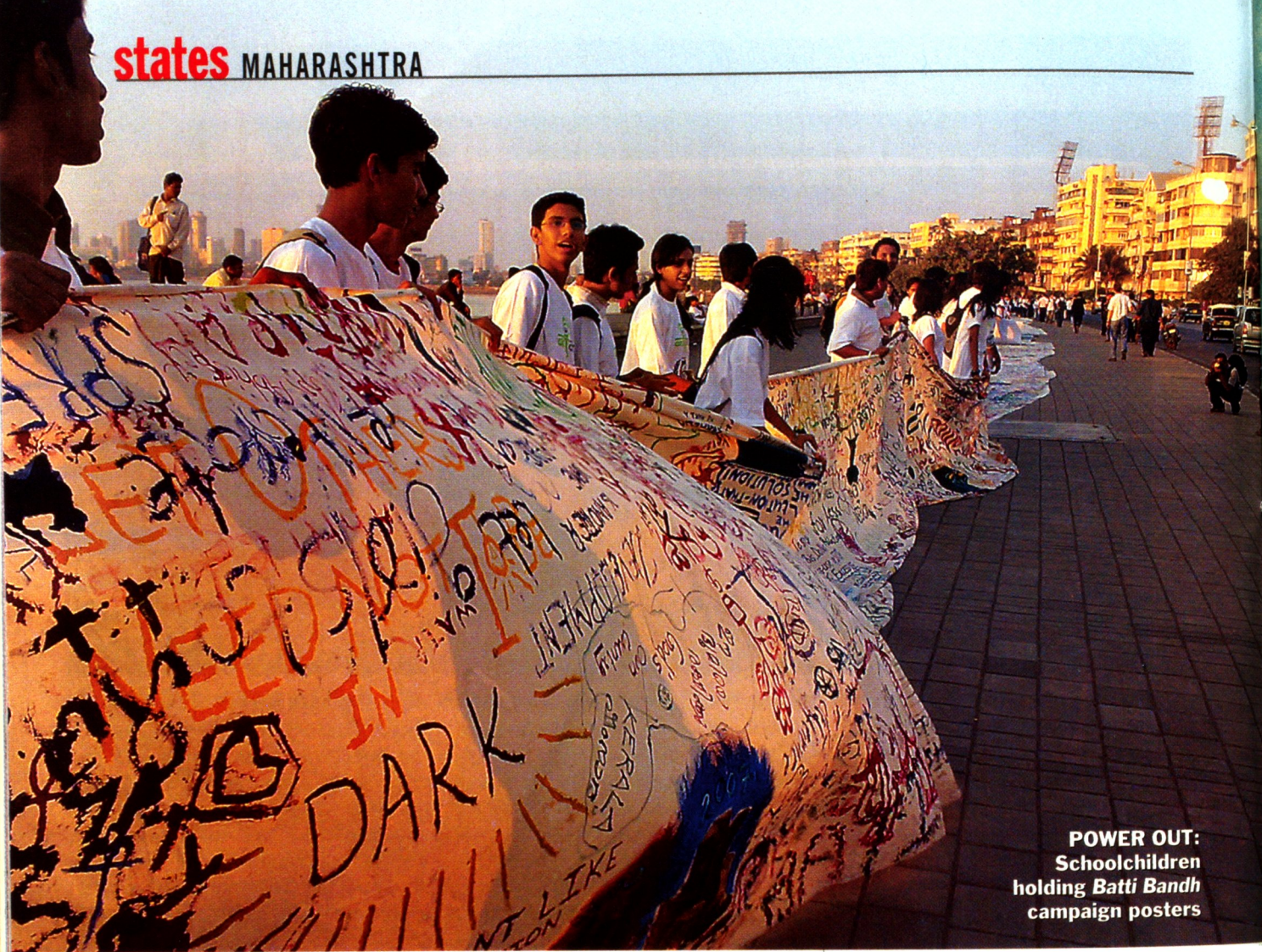




POWER OUT:
Schoolchildren
holding Batti Bandh
campaign posters

BY THE PEOPLE FOR THE PEOPLE

By initiating social awareness campaigns, Mumbaikars are showing how a city should take charge of its own problems

■ By Aditi Pai

Amidst a riot of colours, Mumbai's famed annual Kalaghoda Arts Festival went green this year. With their deft brush strokes, celebrity painters like Pavitra Rajaram, Bose Krishnamachari, Hafeez Contractor and Ratan Batliboi decorated the environment-friendly Reva cars with graffiti art. This particular module of the festival was part of a unique initiative undertaken by Jindal Steel Works and Reva Car

Company to promote the use of eco-friendly cars to reduce pollution. This was no lone example of civic activism in Mumbai which in recent times has seen citizens taking the lead in initiating public campaigns on socially relevant issues. Says Venkatesh Kumar, a political analyst: "No government can be insensitive to the demands of citizens, which assume the shape of a movement. And that is why citizens' campaigns are effective."

Thanks to the citizens' continued protests, another city-wide movement,

the *Ghanta Naad* (ringing bells), is already showing results. The movement started on New Year's eve when hundreds descended upon all green open spaces in the city clanging their cutlery to protest against the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation's (BMC) proposed policy of leasing open spaces measuring 15,000 sqm or more to private caretakers for maintenance. According to the proposed policy, caretakers would be allowed to construct on 25 per cent of the land while the remaining area would be left open for the public. However, a similar policy in the past had resulted in misuse of land by caretakers like in the case of the Matoshree Club at Jogeshwari and the MIG Club in Bandra. Overwhelmed by the protests, BMC has now stalled work on this policy. Explains Adolf D'Souza, citizen activist and a BMC corporator: "Even though we are a working democracy, we are in a state of anarchy now. There isn't a single authority that works responsibly, which is why people take